



# Geekulcha Annual Hackathon 2026

## EVENT BRIEFING & SCHEDULE OF ACTIVITIES

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## Introduction & Guidelines

The Geekulcha Annual Hackathon 2026 will be hosted 25 - 27 September 2026 in Centurion with a virtual option.

## 2026 THEME: BUILD FOR USE

Don't just build to impress, build to be used. Every solution must be genuinely ready for real-world deployment: with identified users, a validated problem, security-by-design, a sustainability plan, and measurable impact.

The theme challenges every team to move beyond the prototype and create something that real people can pick up, rely on, and benefit from, not just on demo day, but long into the future. Every decision made during the hackathon weekend should be guided by one question: Would a real user trust and use this?

The Geekulcha Annual Hackathon attracts a diverse, high-calibre community of technology builders and thinkers from across Africa.

## KEY REQUIREMENTS:

1. Register to get into the Sonke workspace
2. Create / profile a team on Sonke and add team members
3. Submit required material: Powerpoint slides that includes Problem Statement; Solution; Technology Readiness Level (TRL) 3; Technological Architecture; User Journey Story; and a Go-to market strategy.

**SUBMISSION DEADLINE:** 25 August 2026, 23:59

Set to start on Fri, 25 Sep 2026 16:00 and ends on Sun, 27 Sep 2026 16:00. The official hashtag is **#GKHack26**.

NOTE: The numbers above will change as the event proceeds with more teams created or participants having joined.

## Welcome to The Geekulcha Annual Hackathon 2026

Please note the following guidelines for the hackathon (by **room**, we refer to both physical boardrooms and virtual meeting rooms and you will be allocated to different rooms):

# 1. EXPECTATIONS FOR PARTICIPANTS AND TEAMS

a) Present yourself at the physical venue (before 15:30 on the 25th of September) - REMEMBER AN ITEM TO DONATE to the as a participation requirement at the venue or join the call hackathon opening if virtual from 15:30 on the meeting link shared on the calendar.

b) AS A TEAM: You are now challenged to build the solution that is usable for intended users; It must make business sense; it must be secure; is technically feasible

c) You are expected to get ready to complete or go to key sessions as required by facilitators:

- **14:00 - 15:30, Day 1:** Arrive at the physical venue and remember your identity means (ID / Passport / Driver's license) and items specified in the emails for personal needs. Official hackathon kick off is at 16:00.
- **19:00 - 20:00, Day 1:** Work with the mentors to **strengthen your problem statement** (no more than 2 paragraphs) and it must have a sense of reality (cite real data from a credible source; cite any lived experience)
- **11:00 - 12:00, Day 2:** Attend the Hackathon DevLabs - all teams must be represented at the parallel workshops and if you are less than 5 members, choose sessions most relevant to your solution.
- **12:29 - 12:30, Day 2:** Submit your updated Secure System Development Lifecycle (SSDL) - to show how your team thought and, is building with security in the flow.
- **14:00 - 17:00, Day 2:** Join the Hackathon War Rooms in the allocated room (you will receive this allocation on email) and here, you will have 12 minutes with the panel where you will state what you are working and then get guidance to stay with the scope of the hackathon.
- **21:29 - 29:30, Day 2:** Submit your team's Lean Business Canvas (just fill in on Sonke) - it's important to have figures (e.g R50 monthly fee; We need R1 Billion for hosting)
- **08:59 - 09:00, Day 3:** FINAL SUBMISSION of the hackathon (see below on what to submit) - click the green link (top right on desktop) or submissions in your team's centre (click TEAM CENTRE on button).? **IMPORTANT:**

No submission --> No Pitching. No finale. No prizes.

- **10:00 - 12:30, Day 3:** Sales Pitching to a panel in your allocated room for 3 minutes (see section 4 of these guidelines). This is a sales set up and the panel will assess your team with (**pay half prize, pay full prize or not buying at all**) and the final sale

determination to make it to top 12.

- **13:15 - 15:30, Day 3:** Final presentations of the Top 12 teams (to be announced in 4s be due to a verification process), so your team need to be ready for anything.

d) Have Sonke open as a tab throughout the hackathon and submit updates (at own schedule but midnight updates are key) if your team has made a major milestone or if you need mentors' inputs.

## 2. AVAILABLE SUPPORT FOR THE HACKATHON WEEKEND

There are channels (from 22 September 16:00) on Sonke and the **updates channel** is the key challenge to checkout as event hosts are the only ones that post there. Here is how you can find help during the hackathon:

- a) The official email is sonke@geekulcha.dev and key facilitators of the hackathon receive the emails on it.
- b) **VIRTUAL PARTICIPANTS:** The Head of the **Virtual Support Centre** (main hackathon meeting) is Ms Lisa Bashizi and on the 25th of September, use the VIRTUAL CHECK-IN button to indicate your weekend participation (very important).
- c) The Virtual Support Centre will include mentors for different expertise for your needs.
- d) Use the **NEED HELP** button above for specific assistance needs. You may post in the open channels for some of the needs you may have.
- e) Physically, there will be a desk for facilitators of the hackathon and they may assist you on your needs. There will also be a lot of mentors for your assistance.

## 3. WHAT TO SUBMIT ON SUNDAY, 27 SEP. 2026 BEFORE 09:00AM SAST

Have one or two people in your team tasked with submission so that you do not miss anything and we urge to listen carefully and read instructions. Also important, make the judging criteria, your friend. Here is what to submit:

1. **PRESENTATION SLIDES:** Presentation slides the includes he following things: Problem Statement justification - you include charts and pictures; Solution offering; User Journey Story; Technological Architecture; Competitive Analysis; Data Privacy Policies. Slides must be more than 10 at all (they much less for Round 1 presentations / pitching).
2. **DEMO VIDEO LINK:** Less than 90 seconds. You may upload the video and put the link on your project overview on Sonke or in a slide of your deck.

## 4. PRESENTATIONS FLOW FOR 27 SEPTEMBER

Be advised that hackathon assessors will be assessing throughout, using the Sonke platform. Be sure to update and strengthen your team's profile from time to time. Below are presentations flow:

1) The Sales Rooms Pitching (10:00 - ): Up to 3 rooms (that means 3 teams will pitch at a time in a different room) will be set up for the pitches and you will need to prepare the 3 minutes pitch - just sell; Sell Sell and Sell.

***? PRO TIP:** Convince that panel that the there is a problem that needs solving, backed by real / lived / existing evidence (for 20 seconds nje); Tell them what you are offering (the solution / app), how it works and what they may look forward to; NB: how much it costs and how much you need right now (sum of your cost structure); Why this solution standout from any others; You do a quick demo (50 seconds);*

2) Finale Presentations: Top 12 teams of the Geekulcha Annual Hackathon will present before a panel of judges for 5 minutes (focus more on the demo) and then 3 minutes judges QnA.

Understand that you are building for use, not just coding, have your users and what is currently out there in the forefront when building your solution. We wish you the best of luck and HAPPY HACKING

**VERY IMPORTANT:** In order to be judged, all teams must be profiled (even if wotking solo).

# Challenges

## Gov Innovation Platform

South Africa produces many innovative solutions through hackathons and innovation programmes, yet too few reach government. This challenge invites participants to build a platform that connects innovators with public sector opportunities, increases the visibility of local solutions, fosters collaboration, and tracks their journey from idea to real-world impact.

## Open Source Agenda

South Africa has immense open-source talent, yet local solutions often struggle to gain visibility and adoption. This challenge invites participants to build a platform that showcases South African open-source innovations, encourages collaboration, and strengthens the country's open-source ecosystem.

## Street Economy

Street vendors play a vital role in local economies, yet many face low customer engagement. Participants are challenged to create innovative solutions that encourage people to discover, trust, and support informal traders, helping to grow inclusive economic opportunities.

## Train Journey Mapper

Geekulcha will be hosting the Train Tourism Hackathon in 2027 and there is a need to creatively geomap, animate and localise the train journey. Participants are tasked to develop an interactive platform that maps and brings to life the rail journey from Pretoria to Cape Town. The solution should showcase local attractions, culture, and stories along the route, enhancing the hackathon experience while promoting domestic tourism.

## Localised Self-Learning Experiences

Access to quality learning and career development remains unequal for many communities. This challenge focuses on building accessible digital solutions that empower people to learn independently, develop future-ready skills, and connect with education and employment opportunities.

### **Brand New**

Innovation has no boundaries. Teams are welcome to tackle a challenge of their own choosing, provided their solution aligns with the hackathon's judging criteria and demonstrates meaningful impact, creativity, and technical excellence.

### **Blockchain for Impact Use**

Putting Blockchain for practical and impactful use - teams are challenged to come up with up commercially viable use cases.

### **GeoTech for Impact**

Develop a practical technology solution using **data, mapping, AI, or other digital tools** to address real-world challenges in **agriculture or mining**, improving decision-making, resource management, monitoring, or community outcomes

## Judging Criteria

| # | Title                             | Description                                                                                                                                            | Weight |
|---|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|
| 1 | Innovation and Creativity         | Has the proposed a new solution or does it improve an existing one? Is it creatively thought through? Does it have impact potential on intended users? | 15     |
| 2 | Technical Implementation          | Is the solution developed fit for purpose? Does it work? Are chosen technologies fit for scale? Is it efficient?                                       | 15     |
| 3 | Usability and Design              | Does it have an ease of use? Is it appealing to the eye? Does it have an easy flow? Can it be used tomorrow?                                           | 10     |
| 4 | Security and Ethics               | Has the team considered imminent risks and mitigation? Are there policies considered? Is it considerate?                                               | 10     |
| 5 | Business and Presentation         | Does the team have a sound business case with for the solution? Does it have market potential? As s judge, are you buying?                             | 15     |
| 6 | BONUS POINTS: Use of Quantum Tech | Has the team outlined any quantum tech integration (2)? Has the team implemented and integrate the tech?                                               | 5      |

# The Programme

## DAY 1: Fri, 25 September 2026

14:00 - 16:00

Arrival and registration

Everyone

Light lunch will be served between 14:00 - 15:00

16:00 - 16:10

Official kick-off of the hackathon

Hackathon MC and Security Officer

Opening of the hackathon with safety briefing regarding the venue

16:10 - 16:20

East African Keynote: Solutions for impact

Mr Chandi Tome, Founder & CEO at Lolwe AI

Statement to boost up innovation stamina

16:20 - 16:30

Global Keynote: Building a solid architecture

Dr James Stanger, Chief Technology Evangelist at CompTIA

Key knowledge to possess ahead of the start of the hackathon

16:30 - 16:45

South African Keynote: Foresighted Innovation

Mr Pierre Schoonraad, Executive Director at the Centre for Public Service Innovation

Setting context and ability build relevant solutions for the needs of the people or sectors

16:45 - 17:00

Sponsor messages of support

Various sponsors

Introduction of sponsors

17:00 - 17:15

What The Actual Hack: Final Guidance on the hackathon flow

Dr Khanyisile Twabu, University of South Africa

Flow into what is expected from teams for the weekend ahead

17:15 - 17:30

Hackathon Declaration Keynote Address

Dr Noxolo Kubheka-Dlamini, Chief Digital and Information Officer, Telkom

The importance of building for markets and the support that can be utilised

17:30 - 19:10

Hack-away

Teams

Teams at work with guidance from the mentors

19:10 - 20:00

Solution finalisation: Setting key essence

Teams with mentors going to each group, led by Mr Thulani Mabuza, Dr Ronny Mabokela and Mr Prince Dube

All teams at work to ensure that problem statements are sound, relevant and well formed - starting off with facts, pain points and current distress

20:00 - 21:00

Dinner is served

Everyone

Evening boost-up dinner

21:00 - 23:59

Hack-away

Teams

Teams at work with guidance from the mentors

23:59 - 00:00

Progress Update Submission Deadline

All the teams

See link on the right menu to add progress for your team and get mentors feedback

## **DAY 2: Sat, 26 September 2026**

00:00 - 04:00

Hack-away and energy drinks served

Coordination team - powered by Red Bull

Teams at work with guidance from the mentors

04:00 - 07:00

Showers open

Coordination team

Showers at the basement, participants led and guided with access

07:00 - 09:00

Hack-away

Teams

Teams at work with guidance from the mentors

09:00 - 10:00

Breakfast is served

Everyone

Hot breakfast to boost up and break the fast

10:00 - 11:00

Hack-away

Teams

Teams at work with guidance from the mentors

11:00 - 12:00

In-hackathon parallel workshops

Various leads

All teams need to be represented at the workshops

12:00 - 12:30

Hack-away

Teams

Teams at work with guidance from the mentors

12:30 - 13:00

SUBMISSION DEADLINE: Security (SSDC)

All the teams

Fill the SSDLC through the Sonke platform - see link link your team page right panel menu()

13:00 - 14:00

Lunch is served

Everyone

hack My Food: Make your own burgher

14:00 - 17:00

Hackathon War Rooms

Teams and panel

Up to 10 rooms (email for allocation or click War Rooms in the Dashboard on Sonke)

17:00 - 19:00

Hack-away

Teams

Teams at work with guidance from the mentors

19:00 - 20:00

Dinner is served

Everyone

Saturday braai

20:00 - 20:45

Presentations enlightenment

Hackathon panel

WHAT, WHEN and HOW to present

20:45 - 21:59

Hack-away

Teams

Teams at work with guidance from the mentors

21:59 - 21:30

SUBMISSION DEADLINE: Lean Business Canvas

All the teams

See link on the right panel on your team page and then click Lean Business Canvas to fill in

21:30 - 23:59

Hack-away

Teams

Teams at work with guidance from the mentors

23:59 - 00:00

Progress Update Submission Deadline

All the teams

See link on the right menu to add progress for your team and get mentors feedback

## DAY 3: Sun, 27 September 2026

00:00 - 02:00

Demo War Rooms

Teams with mentors

Guidance on how structure the sales pitch and showcase of the solution

00:00 - 04:00

Hack-away and energy drinks served

Coordination team - powered by Red Bull

Teams at work with guidance from the mentors

04:00 - 07:00

Showers open

Coordination team

Showers at the basement, participants led and guided with access

07:00 - 08:59

Hack-away + pitching order announced

Teams

Teams at work with guidance from the mentors

08:59 - 09:00

SUBMISSION DEADLINE: All team material

All the teams

Click **SUBMIT FILES** on Sonke and fill upload your team's material including slides deck all team members, problem statement, solution + features, security considerations, impact and a go-market strategy, link to demo video

09:00 - 10:00

Breakfast is served

Everyone

Hot breakfast to boost up and break the fast

10:00 - 12:30

Round 1 Pitching

All the teams

Each team has 3 minutes to sell their solution

12:30 - 13:30

Lunch is served

Everyone

Sunday Koos

13:30 - 15:00

Top 12 Teams Presentations

Teams determined by the review panel

Each team has 5 minutes to present and demo the solution. Judges have 3 minutes for

QnA. *Opening address by Ms Lydia Sebokedi*

15:00 - 15:10

Judges deliberation

Ms Lisa Bashizi with judges

Winners will set up out to consolidate and determine the winners of the hackathon

15:10 - 15:20

Winners announcement

Key stakeholders

Special prizes and top 3 winning teams announced

15:20 - 15:30

Hackathon closing

Ms Yolisa Dumezweni, Head: Research & Development at Geekulcha

Parting remarks of the Geekulcha Annual Hackathon 2026